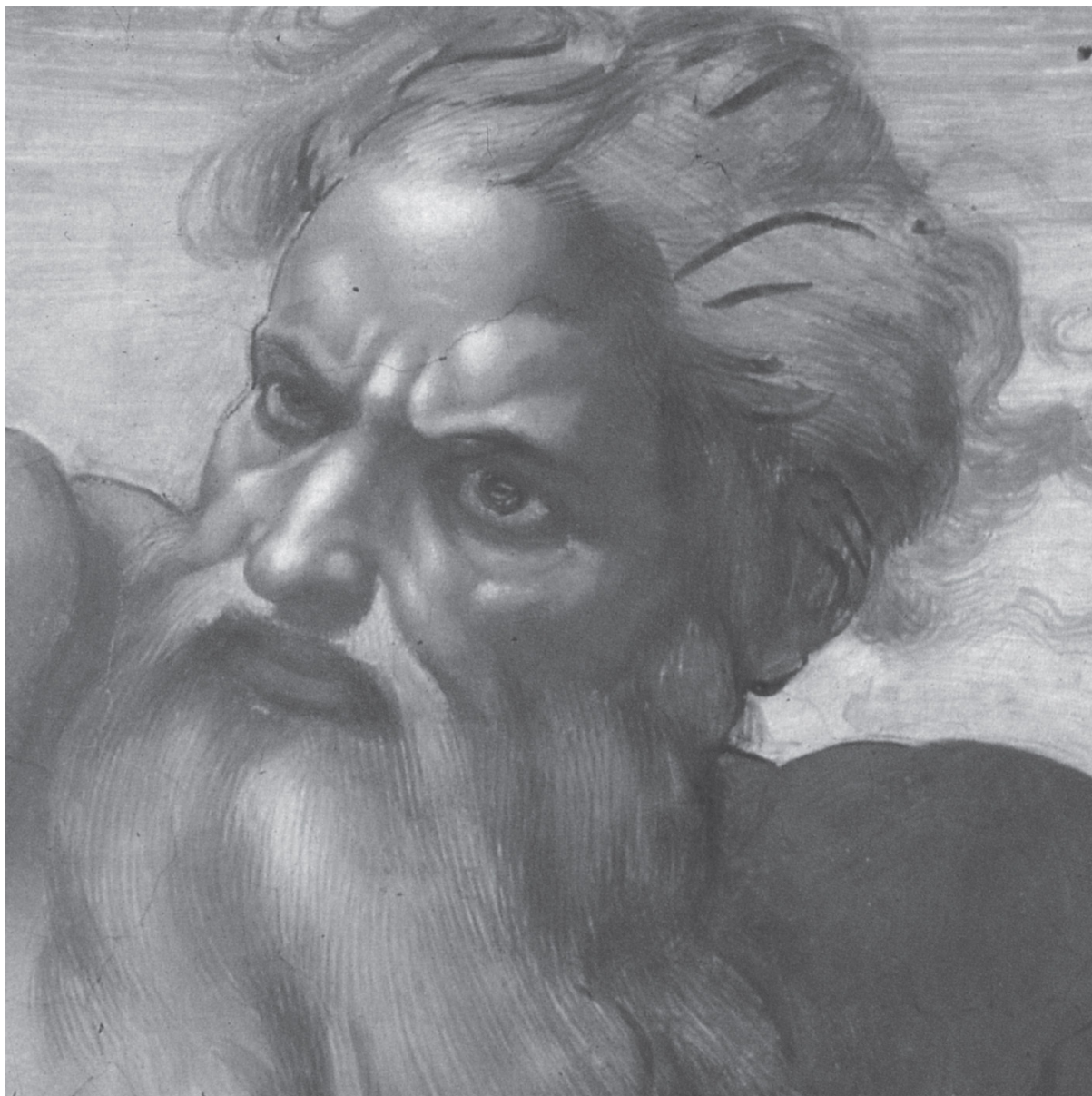


Fresco

From the Italian word for fresh, the term *fresco* describes a method of painting on freshly plastered walls. There are two methods: *buon fresco* and *fresco secco*. For both methods, fresh lime plaster is spread in thin layers over a wall and artists paint on the smooth surface. This final layer of smooth plaster is called the *intonaco*. Only small areas can be completed at a time, and one day's work is called a *giornata*. In *buon fresco*, artists paint on the wet intonaco, before the plaster has dried, which bonds the fresco to the wall. In *fresco secco*, artists paint on a dry intonaco.

Frescoes have been painted by artists at least since the Minoan period. One of the earliest known examples of *buon fresco* is *The Toreador*, or *Bull-Leaping*, made by the Minoans, c.1500 BCE in Knossos in Crete. Ancient Egyptian wall paintings were usually made using the *fresco secco* technique. However, the technique was at its peak during the Italian Renaissance, in works such as Michelangelo's Sistine Chapel ceiling of 1508–12.



Michelangelo, detail from *Creation of the Sun and Moon*, 1511